59.

I TEXTED CRESS, TOLD HER I was home.

She texted back, said she was relieved, which made me relieved.

I hadn't been sure what to expect.

I wanted to see her. And yet we didn't make a plan. Not in that first exchange. There was some distance there, some stiffness.

You sound different, Harry.

Well, I don't feel different.

I didn't want her to think I was different.

A week later, some mates gave a dinner party. Welcome home, Spike! At my mate Arthur's place. Cress turned up with my cousin Eugenie—a.k.a. Euge. I hugged them both, saw the shock on their faces.

They said I looked like a completely different person.

Stockier? Bigger? Older?

Yes, yes, all that. But also something else they couldn't name.

Whatever it was, it seemed frightening or off-putting to Cressida.

We agreed, therefore, that this wasn't a reunion. Couldn't be. Can't have a reunion with someone you don't know. If we wanted to keep seeing each other—and I certainly did—we'd have to start again.

Hello, I'm Cress.

Hello, I'm Haz. Nice to meet you.

60.

I GOT UP EACH day, went to the base, did my work, enjoyed none of it. It felt pointless.

And boring. I was bored to tears.

More, for the first time in years, I was without a purpose. A goal.

What's next? I asked myself every night.